

# **The Examined Society**

Markets, Morals, Justice, and Knowledge – a year-long argument

*“The unexamined life is not worth living.”*

– Socrates, in Plato’s *Apology*

A society is held together by more than its laws. It is held together by markets that coordinate millions of strangers, by moral sentiments that bind them, by institutions that discipline power, and by the fragile habit of admitting and correcting our own mistakes. To understand such a society is to hold these forces in view at once – and no single discipline can do that alone.

This reading group is an experiment in thinking across four traditions together: economics, political philosophy, moral philosophy, and the theory of knowledge. We treat them not as separate subjects but as facets of one question – how people can trade, argue, judge, and decide together.

The authors we read disagree with one another, often profoundly, and we do not read them to be told what to think. We read them to watch a long argument unfold and to learn how to take part in it. Thinkers of opposed temperaments and incompatible conclusions are set beside one another as equals, each given the strongest voice we can manage. No one is treated as an oracle, and no tradition is granted the last word.

What the group offers is not a doctrine but a discipline: the habit of weighing rival arguments, seeing the trade-offs they conceal, resisting easy answers, and arriving at one's own judgments with care. The connections among these thinkers are not supplied in advance. They are yours to make.

## Reading Sequence

### Part I – Sympathy, Commerce, and the Taming of the Passions

#### 1. Hume

Custom, sympathy, justice, property, convention.

#### 2. Smith: Moral Sentiments

Sympathy, the impartial spectator, moral order.

#### 3. Smith: Wealth of Nations

Division of labour, markets, natural liberty, commercial society.

#### 4. Ricardo

Value, rent, distribution, classical political economy.

### Part II – Freedom, Recognition, and the Critique of Capital

#### 5. Kant

Autonomy, dignity, public reason, republican right, cosmopolitan peace.

#### 6. Hegel

Recognition, ethical life, civil society, state, historical freedom.

#### 7. Mill

Utility, liberty, democracy, women's equality, political economy.

#### 8. Marx

Alienation, class, exploitation, surplus value, critique of political economy.

### Part III – How Capitalism Lives, Fails, and Reproduces Itself

#### 9. The Marginal Revolution

Subjective value, marginal utility, choice, neoclassical economics.

#### 10. Schumpeter

Entrepreneurship, innovation, creative destruction, capitalism and democracy.

#### 11. Keynes

Uncertainty, aggregate demand, unemployment, stabilization.

#### 12. Hayek

Capital theory, the Keynes debate, the knowledge problem, spontaneous order.

#### 13. Polanyi

The embedded economy, fictitious commodities, the double movement, the critique of market society.

#### 14. Lachmann

Expectations, radical uncertainty, capital heterogeneity, the market process.

## Part IV – Economics Beyond the Market

### 15. Arrow

Social choice, the impossibility theorem, collective rationality.

### 16. Becker

Rational choice beyond markets; human capital, family, crime, discrimination.

### 17. Coase

Transaction costs, property rights, the firm, law and economics.

### 18. Buchanan

Public choice, constitutional economics, politics without romance.

### 19. Sowell

Dispersed knowledge, decision-making processes, incentives, trade-offs, and the constrained vision.

### 20. Hirschman

Exit, voice, and loyalty; development and possibilism; the passions and the interests.

### 21. Ostrom

The commons, collective action, polycentric governance, self-governance.

## Part V – Justice, Equality, and the Limits of the State

### 22. Harsanyi

The impartial-observer theorem, utilitarianism, welfare economics.

### 23. Rawls

Justice as fairness, the original position, the basic structure, the difference principle.

### 24. Nozick

Entitlement theory, self-ownership, the minimal state.

### 25. Cohen

Self-ownership reconsidered, luck egalitarianism, the critique of Rawls and Nozick alike.

### 26. Sen

Capabilities, development as freedom, public reasoning.

### 27. Berlin

Value pluralism, negative liberty, the critique of final answers.

### 28. Arendt

The public realm, plurality, action, the space of appearance, freedom.

### 29. Pettit

Liberty, non-domination, the free state, and moral compass.

## Part VI – How Knowledge Grows and Why It Needs Freedom

### 30. Russell

Logic, scientific method, the honesty of the changing mind, analytic liberalism.

### 31. Popper

Falsifiability, critical rationalism, the open society.

### 32. Kuhn

Paradigms, scientific revolutions, the challenge to Popper.

### **33. Probability**

Chance, rational belief, risk and uncertainty, and the limits of calculation.

## **Final Meeting – Seven Modern Strains**

### **34. Seven Modern Strains**

Democratic erosion; the broken information commons; the new inequality regime; climate in the decisive decade; artificial intelligence and concentrated power; geopolitical fragmentation and the return of war; demographic and social recession.

## **Before Each Meeting**

For meetings 1–33, participants will receive a designated note on the author – a concise guide to the thinker’s work and its central problems, in the style of these sessions – together with a short original excerpt from the author’s own writing. The two are meant to be read side by side: the note to orient, the excerpt to let the author speak in their own voice. The combined reading for these meetings will not exceed 50–60 pages. Meeting 34 is the exception: it uses one longer synthesis note that brings the full series to bear on seven modern strains.